6

YEARS OF CONSOLIDATION

In March 1992, after returning from the gruelling Australian tour and the World Cup, I badly needed a few weeks of relaxation. Our next international assignment was a tour of South Africa towards the end of the year and we had several months off in the interim. Fortunately for me, I managed to spend the first few days at home. I played tennis-ball cricket with friends and it was terrific to be able to unwind in familiar surroundings.

I was playing downstairs with my friends one day when Ajit called down from our apartment balcony to say that there was a phone call from Yorkshire County Cricket Club and that they wanted me to play for them! I came up to take the call and was very excited at the offer. I did not bother asking about the contract and other details and was determined to make the most of this opportunity to play in the County Championship in England. That I would have to cook, do my laundry, drive and perform all the other household chores never occurred to me at the time. A few days after the conversation, the CEO of Yorkshire CCC, Chris Hassell, came over to India to complete the formalities. We met at Thane, a suburb of Mumbai, where I was playing a match. I signed the contract at the ground, proud to become Yorkshire's first overseas-born player in 128 years.

A Yorkshire lad

I left for England towards the end of April 1992, right after my nineteenth birthday, and stayed there for three and a half months. It was